

EXCAVATIONS AT GREAT HOUSE FARM, LLANDOUGH, CARDIFF, SOUTH GLAMORGAN

A PRELIMINARY REPORT

by

Alan Thomas and Neil Holbrook

for

Ideal Homes Wales Ltd.



Cotswold Archaeological Trust

EXCAVATIONS AT GREAT HOUSE FARM, LLANDOUGH, CARDIFF, SOUTH GLAMORGAN

Preliminary Report

SENIOR STAFF

SITE SUPERVISOR:	MIKE INGS
SITE PLANNER:	JOHN DALTON
SITE PHOTOGRAPHER:	DAVE GILBERT
REPORT ILLUSTRATIONS:	RICK MORTON & GILLY SHARPE

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CONTENTS

LIST OF FIGURES

1. INTRODUCTION	1
2. LOCATION AND GEOLOGY	2
3. HISTORICAL BACKGROUND AND PREVIOUS EXCAVATION	3
4. EXCAVATION RESULTS	6
5. THE FINDS	11
6. THE RADIOCARBON DATES	13
7. GENERAL CONCLUSIONS	14
8. ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS	18
9. BIBLIOGRAPHY	19

LIST OF FIGURES

Figure 1	Location of Llandough.	21
Figure 2	1979 and 1994 excavation areas.	22
Figure 3	Site plan.	23
Figure 4	Overall plan of the cemetery defining Areas I-IV.	24
Figure 5	Distribution of stone-lined graves, wooden coffins and pillow-stone burials.	25
Figure 6	Distribution of finds.	26
Figure 7	Distribution of Late Iron Age, Roman and Bii pottery.	27

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PRELIMINARY REPORT**

1. INTRODUCTION

1.1 In March 1994 Cotswold Archaeological Trust was commissioned by Wyn Thomas & Partners on behalf of their clients, Ideal Homes Wales Ltd. to undertake the excavation of part of a site to the north of the church of St. Dochdwy, Llandough, Cardiff in advance of a residential development. The site had been considered to be of potential archaeological importance owing to its proximity to a presumed early Christian monastic foundation (eg. RCAHMW 1988), and when the Vale of Glamorgan Borough Council granted outline planning permission for residential development in March 1990 a condition required that a field evaluation survey be undertaken. Accordingly, Glamorgan-Gwent Archaeological Trust was commissioned to undertake the survey. Eight trenches were dug, suggesting to the excavators that much of the site had been disturbed by post-medieval quarrying and levelling. Nearer the church disarticulated human skeletal remains which appeared to have been disturbed from their original context were located (CBA 1990, 66).

1.2 In March 1992 full planning permission was granted for residential development, with no conditions requiring further archaeological work. However, in March 1994, Ideal Homes Wales voluntarily undertook to sponsor an excavation of that part of the site which had been designated by Glamorgan-Gwent Archaeological Trust (in the light of the evaluation results) as being of medium-high archaeological potential, and where preservation *in-situ* was not possible. The total area to be examined was approximately 0.1 ha.

1.3 At an early stage in the excavation it became clear that the site contained numerous burials which continued beyond the bounds of the excavation area into the zone defined, as a result of the evaluation, as being of non-existent to low archaeological potential. Many of the burials lay only a few centimetres below the topsoil. Consequently, Ideal Homes Wales readily agreed to fund a much enlarged programme of investigation, and the area of excavation was extended to the north, west and east to cover the full area of surviving inhumations. Ideal Homes Wales endured a lengthy delay to their building schedule as a result of the increased scale of works, although CAT sought to assist the developers by excavating the site in phases which were released in turn for construction to commence. In the event a 0.22ha area was investigated and work finally ceased on site in September 1994.

1.4 Since completion of the excavation, work has concentrated on initial processing of records, indexing and checking of the site archive, initial scanning of the artefacts, and obtaining radiocarbon dates to confirm chronology. The results outlined in this report are therefore necessarily provisional, and may be subject to change as further research is undertaken. Nevertheless it is hoped that the broad conclusions and overall chronology will remain valid.

2. LOCATION AND GEOLOGY

2.1 The present day settlement at Llandough lies to the north of Penarth and about 3.5km. from the centre of Cardiff (fig. 1). Although now a suburb of Cardiff it was until recently little more than a village, occupying the gently sloping ground near the crest of an escarpment, which itself delimits the west side of the low lying ground of the Ely and Taff estuaries. The uppermost part of this escarpment is made up of Lower Lias, which in this area overlies rocks of the Rhaetic series and Red Marls (Owen-John 1988, 128-9). The excavation site occupies an irregularly shaped and relatively flat area, c43m above sea level, to the north of the church of St. Dochdwy. Here, the Lias took the form of alternating thin horizontal bands of rock and yellow clay, sloping gently to the south and west.

3. HISTORICAL BACKGROUND AND PREVIOUS EXCAVATION

Introduction

3.1 The church of St Dochdwy at Llandough occupies a site of considerable historical interest, through its well-known association with the site of an Early Christian monastic foundation. Its archaeological potential was also established by excavations to the south of the church by the Barry and Vale Archaeological Group (Beare 1963) and the Glamorgan-Gwent Archaeological Trust (Owen-John 1988). The latter excavation established the survival of significant archaeological deposits dating from the late Iron Age through to the post-medieval period (fig. 2).

Iron Age occupation

3.2 Evidence for a late Iron Age structure was recovered from the 1979 excavation in the form of a possible roundhouse. This was interpreted as a possible farmstead, perhaps supplementing agricultural produce with the natural resources of the nearby River Ely and the sea (Owen-John 1988, 129).

Roman occupation

3.3 The Iron Age structure was superseded by the construction of a well-preserved Roman villa, probably in the 2nd century AD. A major expansion appears to have taken place in the early 3rd century after which the site was occupied until the early 4th century. It is also possible that after the demise of the villa at least part of its buildings were utilised for a substantial time in the post-Roman period (Owen-John 1988, 144, 152).

Post-Roman monastic settlement

3.4 A number of burials, probably at least 30, were disturbed by building operations outside of the 1979 main excavation area and it was possible to conduct salvage excavation on two of

these. Radiocarbon dates of 8th-9th century AD were produced from both burials. A further burial within the excavation area produced an 11th-12th century AD radiocarbon date. The excavator of the site noted that the burials could belong to the monastic graveyard; the cemetery of the lay community situated close to the religious settlement; or be the result of a possible Scandinavian sea-borne attack on the monastery (Owen-John 1988, 145-7). Further archaeological evidence for post-Roman religious activity is provided by the existence of a decorated cross shaft, dated to the late 10th or 11th century, within the churchyard. The presence of early medieval inscribed stones and Christian sculpture is rightly used as a major indicator of the antiquity of a church site, although it has to be borne in mind that they may have been brought into a churchyard from elsewhere for safe keeping. However, the cross was *in-situ* in the 1690's when a sketch was made by or for Edward Llwyd. Descriptions of the cross can be found in Nash-Williams (1950, 206) and RCAHMS (1976, No. 938). In addition to its sculptured ornament it is inscribed IRBICI (*The stone of Irbic*). This is presumably the name of the person commemorated by the cross or responsible for its erection. The current location of the cross to the south of the church is not one of antiquity, as a photograph kindly supplied to us by Diane Brook and Mark Redknap, and probably dated to between 1870-1880, shows the cross standing to the west of the church.

3.5 These two pieces of archaeological evidence can now be compared with the historical sources for post-Roman monastic settlement. First amongst these is the place-name of Llandough itself, first attested in the 7th century, and to be interpreted as "*the cemetery or church of Docco*". Docco (or Docheu) is traditionally believed to be a 5th century British saint who had links with both Cornwall and south Wales. Later sources record that he became a bishop and died around AD 473 (although this date only appears much later; Knight 1984b, 378). A monastery which bore his name was founded in Cornwall at St. Kew, near Wadebridge (*monasterium quod Docco vocatur*): it may be significant that in the 6th century Life of St. Samson the community is said to have been in existence for long enough for it to be noted that it had suffered a decline in the standard of religious practice. In south Wales two sites bear the name of Docco: Llandough near Cowbridge (where significant pre-Norman activity has yet to be found) and the present site. It is surely correct therefore to interpret the frequent references to a monastery at Llandough in the period 650-1075 (according to the chronology of W. Davies) contained within the Welsh charters as referring to our site. The

monastery may possibly have been transferred from an earlier foundation in Cardiff itself (Wade-Evans 1943, 125). Of the six monasteries which are likely to have existed in Glamorgan in the post-Roman period, the sources suggest only Llantwit Major and Llancarfan may have surpassed Llandough in importance.

3.6 It is not entirely certain when the monastery was abandoned although the cross shaft and documentary sources certainly point to significant religious activity into the 11th century. However, it is unlikely that the monastery survived long after the Norman Conquest. Indeed, the rise of Llandaff, just 3 miles away, to an episcopal centre at this time may have led to the resources and revenues of Llandough being diverted to its neighbour (Knight 1984b, 379). Certainly the “village” of Llandough was granted to Tewkesbury Abbey at the close of the 11th century.

Medieval occupation

3.7 A 19th century correspondent noted that “at a short distance from the church, to the south-east, is a small circular mound, commanding the entrances of the rivers Ely and Taff, and probably an outpost for the defence of those rivers” (Lewis 1843, 530). This could well refer to an early castle, possibly a motte or ringwork on a spur of land south-east of the church, unfortunately destroyed for the construction of a farm in the mid-19th century (Thomas 1988, 177). Otherwise little is known of this earthwork.

3.8 Two large medieval buildings, possibly of late 12th century date, were also found in the 1979 excavation, one possibly part of a barn and the other a dovecote. Pits, crude areas of paving and sections of walling were also apparent. It is possible that the two structures equate to a monastic grange belonging to Tewkesbury Abbey (Owen-John 1988, 147-153). At the Dissolution the grange was confiscated by the Crown and sold (Thomas 1988, 177).

3.9 Part of the medieval village of Llandough was excavated in 1963 when a corner of a substantial building of 12th or 13th century date was uncovered. A gully containing three human skeletons of probable 13th century date was also exposed (Beare 1963). Further structures were revealed during the 1979 watching brief (Owen-John 1988, 155).

3.10 The current church was constructed in the mid-19th century but was built on the site of a previous church with medieval origins. The current graveyard boundary probably also dates to the Victorian re-building of the church as a map of 1786, kindly provided by Diane Brook from her unpublished Ph.D thesis, shows this earlier church with a rectangular boundary. Both church and boundary were enlarged by the time of a map of 1824, while the current boundary is shown on a map of 1878.

3.11 North of the church in the area covered by the excavation the land was occupied by the farmhouse and outbuildings of Great House Farm (demolished 1988). The original date of the farmhouse is uncertain. However, medieval fabric may have been incorporated into a 17th century house, reconstructed in the 19th century (RCAHMW 1988).

4. EXCAVATION RESULTS

Preservation.

4.1 It is clear that the original ground level of the cemetery had been reduced at some point(s) after it became disused. Over much of the cemetery, particularly to the north and west articulated skeletons, often in very poor condition, were found only centimetres below the modern ground level. Although no skeletons were found in the north-eastern corner of the excavation and only a few in the north-western part of the site, it is almost certain that burials here had been removed by later truncation. The full extent of the cemetery to the east and west cannot therefore be certain. Much of the levelling was presumably associated with the construction of Great House Farm and its outbuildings. Extensive post-medieval quarrying has also removed large parts of the cemetery. It is therefore certain that the cemetery contained far more burials immediately after its disuse than survived up to the point of excavation.

4.2 A total of 858 inhumations were recorded of which 434 were in a good state of preservation with most of the skeleton intact. A further 153 skeletons were less well preserved but were on average between 30-70% intact. The remaining 271 were very

fragmentary. The vast majority of the skeletons from the latter two categories were recovered from the northern part of the site reflecting the intensive use of this area for burial (fig. 3).

4.3 In addition 152 discrete areas of disarticulated human bone groups were identified, mostly within the fills of later burials and reflecting the disturbance of earlier graves. The vast majority of these bone groups occurred in the northern part of the site and again reflect the intensive use of this area for burial. In four instances (B583; B586; B776; and B906), the disturbance of earlier burials was recognised with the deliberate re-burial of the disturbed bone in a linear arrangement beside the freshly dug grave.

Spatial Distribution.

4.4 With the lack of general stratigraphy and the non-survival of features such as walls and ditches it is necessary to analyse the spatial distribution of the burials in order to gain an understanding of the development of the cemetery. The burials at Llandough appear to occur in four areas (fig. 4). Area I comprised a possible curvilinear cemetery, bounded to the north-west by a line of burials on a sw-ne alignment, changing to the east to more of an east-west alignment. Apart from the orientation of these burials no physical barrier such as a fence, wall or ditch was detected. However, to the north and west of this alignment a gap of c1m, occasionally cut by later burials, was apparent. It may be that this gap represents the former existence of a physical barrier, subsequently removed by ground truncation. Certainly the ground to the north-east of this burial alignment had been reduced after the cemetery had fallen into disuse.

4.5 Area II lay in the western part of the site and consisted of deliberately placed rows of occasionally intercutting inhumations. The full western extent of these burials was not established and ground levelling has probably removed much of its northern extent. However, a shallow ditch on an almost north-south alignment may delimit this area of burials to the east as it was not cut by the burials. Unfortunately, much of this feature had been destroyed by modern disturbance and its full significance is uncertain (fig. 4).

4.6 To the north and west of Area I and on the same general alignment lay further burials

(Area III) which continue to the south-west to cut the original burials in Area II. These include several graves forming a distinct sw-ne line for c12m lying directly north of and apparently respecting the postulated northern boundary of the Area I cemetery. This line included an interspaced, near north-south burial (B381). It is possible that the burials in this area formed an extension to the burials in Area I. The full northern extent of this expanded cemetery is unclear as again no feature such as a boundary ditch or wall was detected. However, further to the north this extension was continued to the northern edge of the site, close to a steep escarpment and was the area most intensively used for burial (Area IV). Here, the burials were generally on an east-west alignment and included a distinct row of east-west aligned graves (fig. 4).

Burial postures.

4.7 The vast majority of the inhumations in all three areas at Llandough were extended and supine. However, there were at least 8 instances of differing burial postures.

4.8 Flexed burials. Five flexed burials were recovered (B55, B68, B202, B333 and B834). They are widely spaced over the cemetery, do not form a coherent group and occur in infant, child and adult burials.

4.9 Crouched, prone and pit burials. Single examples of adjacent crouched and prone burials were recovered (B474 and B470). In addition, 6m to the west, a further burial (B601) appeared to have been placed in a pit so that the torso sloped downwards at an angle of c45 degrees. This burial produced a potsherd of late Iron Age date. Unfortunately the legs of this burial had been removed by modern trenching. All three of these burials occurred towards the northern edge of Area IV.

4.10 Arm and leg positions. The arm and leg positions have not yet been studied in detail. However, the arms occur in a variety of positions, usually straight or crossed on the chest, waist or abdomen. There are also rare instances where one or both arms have been raised by the head (eg. B80 and B98). The legs are usually both straight although there are rare examples where the legs have been crossed (eg. B89).

Burial Groups.

4.11 There are very many instances of intercutting graves, especially in Area IV reflecting the intensive use of this part of the cemetery. There are also several instances where one inhumation has been placed directly on top of another, although it is uncertain whether these are contemporary burials. There was also a single instance of a paired burial in Area III, where two inhumations appeared to have been placed side by side (B206/212).

4.12 A large amount of infant burials were also apparent in Areas III and IV, probably representing the final use of at least this part of the cemetery, as they cut and overlie earlier adult interments.

Age, Sex and Pathology.

4.13 Study of the age, sex, and pathology of the inhumations has yet to commence. However, infants, juveniles and adults are all represented, along with a single instance of a pregnant female (B240). Instances of abnormal pathological development were apparent in several skeletons.

Burial Rites

4.14 Most of the burials in all three areas were plain interments. However, evidence for stone linings and wooden coffins was recovered from a few graves (fig. 5).

4.15 The evidence for wooden coffins was mostly in the form of black staining around the edge and bottom of the grave cut. Sixteen instances of such staining were noted in all four areas of the cemetery. Often these stains were very fragmentary but in a few instances surrounded much of the skeleton. Several graves also produced very small corroded iron fragments which may on analysis turn out to be coffin nails.

4.16 A total of 14 burials contained varying degrees of deliberate stone-packing around the edges of the grave cut, re-using parts of the bedrock removed when the grave was dug. Few

of these graves were totally stone-lined although the vast majority of these graves occurred in Area I.

4.17 Several graves also contained evidence for burial in shrouds, exhibited normally by a 'hunching' of the shoulders.

4.18 Four graves containing pillow stones for the head (B18, B61, B74, B81) occurred as a group within Area I. A few Roman potsherds were recovered from the fills of both B18 and B61. In addition three burials in Area III (B536, B554 and B635) contained stone supports either side of the skull.

4.19 Nine burials, mostly in Area I, displayed signs of possible markers. In particular B39 contained a distinct headstone and B110 (and possibly B373) contained a vertical stone marker at its feet. All three of these graves produced sherds of Roman pottery. The other burials displayed stones near the top of the skull, possibly supports for some type of grave marker.

The Post-Cemetery Timber Building.

4.20 In the north-east corner of the excavation the remains of a timber building were recovered (fig. 3). The full ground plan of this building did not survive due to later levelling but the remaining post-holes suggest a rectangular structure. Two paired post-holes in its western side may form an entrance. No floors or other internal deposits survived and it is therefore difficult to assign a function. Previous excavation suggests that the monastic grange lay to the south of the church (Owen-John 1988) and it may be that the building was completely unconnected with any sort of religious usage. The building clearly post-dates the use of the cemetery as some of the post-holes clearly cut through earlier graves. A total of 122 medieval potsherds were recovered in the excavation, all but five of which were from the backfill of the post-holes of the building, and presumably therefore relating to its abandonment. Until further analysis has been undertaken of this material only a broad date range of the 12-14th century can be offered for the demolition of the structure.

Other Archaeology.

4.21 To the west of the medieval building a ditch ran from near the northern edge of the site, turning to the south-west. Its date is uncertain although it cut and overlay burials. Interestingly its alignment respects the curvilinear aspect of the cemetery for much of its length. It survived as a shallow feature and it could pre-date or post-date the medieval building.

4.22 At some point much of the site had been the subject of intense quarrying. One large quarry bisected the excavation and others were apparent to the west of the site during the construction of two houses. They had been backfilled with what appeared to be a slurry-type deposit. The date of their excavation and backfill is uncertain, but a large part of the cemetery must have been removed by these quarrying operations.

4.23 Stone walls and demolition deposits apparent in the excavation all belong to Great House Farm and its outbuildings. The farm was constructed in the 17th century but may have had medieval origins (RCAHMS 1988).

5. THE FINDS

5.1 Very few of the graves at Llandough contained grave goods (fig. 6). One burial (B796) contained a complete Roman brooch (Colchester Derivative type; 1st century AD) and three (B40, B470 and B547) contained glass beads, also of Roman date. Two contained knife blades (B34 and B898). B449 contained an unidentified iron object, possibly some type of belt, consisting of bands around the waist of a skeleton. This is currently being examined by the National Museum of Wales. Five burials (B32, B87, B94, B296, and B326) contained iron hob-nails, a distinctive late Roman burial tradition. Several graves also contained quartz and rounded limestone pebbles. Quartz pebbles have been found in association with graves on other Early Christian cemeteries and in Wales have been found in pre-12th century graves at Pennant Melangell (Edwards and Lane 1992, 11) and at Capel Maelog (James 1992, 98). They have also been found within the fill of a holy well at Llandegla (Edwards and Lane 1992, 8).

5.2 A total of 320 potsherds were recovered from the excavation, of which 125 were found in grave fills (fig. 7). The majority of the latter proved to be of 3rd-4th century date. A significant sherd amongst the assemblage is a single fragment of *ceramique a l'eponge* from an unstratified context. This fabric was produced in south-west France in the late 3rd-4th centuries, and has a predominately south-western coastal distribution in Britain. Fourteen sherds of late Iron Age pottery together with small quantities of animal bone, flint, glass, copper alloy, lead and slag were also recovered from some of the grave fills. Four graves yielded mid-4th century Roman coins from their fills (B59, B87, B93, B110).

5.3 Of major significance in terms of understanding both the chronology and status of Llandough is the recognition of five sherds of imported Bii amphora from a variety of grave fills. There is now a body of evidence for the importation of fine wares and amphorae into post-Roman western Britain, most probably originating from the Aegean or Constantinople itself. The main period of importation would appear to be the 75 years between AD 475-550 (Fulford 1989). The discovery of sherds of Bii amphora, a type made mainly along the southern coast of Asia Minor, especially around the Golfe D'Alexandrette, and generally considered to have carried olive-oil, is important from a chronological aspect in providing archaeological evidence of 6th century activity at Llandough. No less significant, however, is that these imported wares, which were never common, are found on comparatively few sites. In south Wales by far the most significant site is the defended hilltop enclosure at Dinas Powys, 2km from Llandough, which has produced fine wares and amphorae in quantity. The interpretation of Dinas Powys is uncertain, although the high quality metalworking and range of exotic imports point to a site of high status. By implication therefore the same will be true for Llandough. The nature of the relationship between Dinas Powys and Llandough, if any, is one for future discussion.

6. THE RADIOCARBON DATES

6.1. Bones from 4 burials were submitted for radiocarbon dating (fig. 3). Two yielded insufficient collagen for conventional analysis and were sent for AMS determination. The results are:

Lab. Ref.	Burial Number	C14 date (B.P.)	1 Sigma calib.
Beta-76463	2	1570 $\pm$ 70	AD 420-590
Beta-76464	65	1170 $\pm$ 60	AD 790-970
Beta-76465	228	1070 $\pm$ 50	AD 960-1015
Beta-76466	380	1210 $\pm$ 60	AD 770-890

6.2. Burial 2 is one of a group of stone-lined graves within Area I. The radiocarbon date from this burial and the imported amphora fit together well to suggest that the possible curvilinear cemetery (Area I) was in use at sometime, or throughout, the 5th-6th centuries. Burial 65 also occurs within Area I and suggests that this cemetery was still in use between the late 8th-mid-10th centuries. Burial 228 occurs in Area III and within a clear linear arrangement of graves just to the north of the postulated Area I boundary and indicates burial here within the latter part of the 10th or early 11th century. Burial 380 occurs in a wooden coffin within Area II and indicates burial here between the late 8th-late 9th centuries.

7. GENERAL CONCLUSIONS

Introduction

7.1 The archaeology of the early Welsh church has received little attention compared with that of many other parts of Britain and Ireland, partly due to the meagerness of the documentary sources and more importantly the scantiness of the upstanding remains. Most of the emphasis has been on sculpture. However, the volume of archaeological excavation in Wales has greatly increased since the late 1960's and rescue work has been carried out on a number of minor ecclesiastical sites and cemeteries. Many of these sites have yet to reach final publication (Edwards and Lane 1992, 1-2). The excavation at Llandough can now be seen to represent a major addition to the corpus of knowledge on this topic in Wales.

Iron Age and Roman Activity

7.2 Many early Welsh cemeteries had their roots in the prehistoric past (Edwards and Lane 1992, 6) and from this point of view the recovery of a few flints and 14 potsherds of late Iron Age date is significant. All can be considered as residual in later graves with the possible exception of a late Iron Age potsherd in pit burial 601. Pit burials are well attested in the late Iron Age in central southern Britain, and seem to have been particularly popular in the period prior to the Roman conquest. It has been suggested that the deposition of isolated skeletons in pits must be considered atypical, and that the bodies were those of criminals, social outcasts, outsiders and the like, deliberately denied the customary funeral ceremony (Harding 1974, 113). If this burial is of late Iron Age date it is presumably associated with the settlement beneath the Roman villa 150m to the south.

7.3 A total of 105 sherds of Roman pottery were recovered from stratified contexts. Seventy of these occur within Area I and 35 in Areas III and IV. This pottery is heavily orientated to the later 3rd-4th century, and it may be significant that the villa to the south appears to have been abandoned in the first quarter of the 4th century. Roman grave goods were also recovered, in the form of the beads and the Colchester-derivative brooch in perfect condition. The latter is unlikely to date after the 1st century AD. If any of the burials at Llandough are

fully Roman, as opposed to post-Roman, the brooch burial would seem a likely candidate. Two of the burials containing Roman beads, which are spatially associated in the northern part of the cemetery, may also be of a similar date. Of further interest is a group of east-west aligned graves at the southern edge of the site (i.e. nearest the church) which might date to the late Roman period. Within this group five burials contained iron hob-nails, a well-attested Roman burial tradition which was widely practised in rural areas of southern England from the late 2nd into the late 4th century (fig. 6). Their presence is often taken to suggest that the dead needed a good pair of shoes for the journey into the underworld. One of the hob-nail burials (B87) also produced a Roman coin of AD 330-45 from the grave fill, suggesting a mid-late 4th century date for the burial. A further three burials, from the same vicinity as those containing hob-nails, also produced Roman coins of the period AD 330-50. Without a more comprehensive programme of radiocarbon dating it is impossible to fully define the scope of Roman burial on the site. However, at this early stage the possibility of the post-Roman cemetery having Roman origins cannot easily be dismissed. Indeed, the occurrence of Christian churches and cemeteries on Roman villa sites is a phenomenon known throughout most of western Europe and raises the possibility that a Roman villa and/or its estate had been taken over in working order by the early medieval Church. We may note by way of comparison that the sub-Roman, and apparently Christian cemetery at Llantwit Major, was cut into the ruins of a Roman villa (Knight 1984b, 377-8). Indeed, the suggestion that part of the villa buildings to the south of St. Dochdwy's church were utilised in the post-Roman period is of great interest (Owen-John 1979, 144 and 152).

The Post-Roman Cemeteries

7.4 The excavation at Llandough represents the largest Early Christian cemetery excavated in Wales to date. However, it is clear that much of the cemetery within the excavated area has been destroyed by lowering of the ground level, particularly in the north-western and north eastern parts of the site. Much of this levelling is presumably associated with Great House Farm and its outbuildings. Extensive quarrying has also removed large parts of the burial ground.

7.5 Spatially, the cemetery can be divided into four areas. Areas I and II appear to be the earliest as the former is respected by and the latter is cut by graves belonging to the Area III expansion. The radiocarbon dates and the imported Bii amphorae suggest that the possible curvilinear cemetery (Area I) was in use at sometime, or throughout, the 5th-6th centuries. Burial 65 also occurs within Area I and suggests that this part of the cemetery was still being used for burial between the late 8th-mid 10th centuries.

7.6 The radiocarbon date from Area II suggests that this part of the cemetery was in use during the period of the late 8th-late 9th centuries, and was therefore at least partly contemporary with Area I. We might perhaps generally note that similar regular burial in rows is attested at the small cemetery excavated at the Atlantic Trading Estate, Barry, which could have spanned the period from the 2nd-10th centuries (James 1992, 96-7). Both cemeteries appear to have been replaced by the expanded, possibly curvilinear cemetery of Area III. The radiocarbon date from this area suggests that it was in use in the latter part of the 10th or early 11th centuries. Further to the north the expansion appears to have continued, possibly until the demise of the monastery, with distinct east-west aligned graves (Area IV).

7.7 Perhaps the most interesting component of the entire cemetery is the identification of the possible boundary of a curvilinear churchyard (Area I). Charles Thomas first pointed out the likely antiquity of such curvilinear churchyard enclosures, also hinting that the concept of circular enclosures might be inherited from the pagan past (Thomas 1971, 38-43, 51-3). Indeed, rounded churchyards are now generally thought to indicate pre-Norman church foundations in the Celtic west (Brook 1992, 78). The 5th-6th century radiocarbon date from Burial 2 in Area I and the Bii amphora sherds confirm this view for Llandough.

7.8 Given the expansion of the cemetery represented by Areas III and IV the cemetery at Llandough must have been very large in area. This is again of particular interest given the suggestion by Charles Thomas that the size of ecclesiastical enclosures might be informative, with the greater the area enclosed the more important the site. Large churchyard areas were suggested to indicate the sites of early major churches and this has been confirmed by the work of Diane Brook in the Vale of Glamorgan. Her work indicates that large churchyards (ie. c1 acre or more) seem to be linked with early high-status sites. (Brook 1992, 86). The

relationship with the burials discovered well to the south of the church in the 1979 excavation is uncertain but in need of re-examination.

7.9 The vast majority of graves at Llandough were simple inhumations laid on their back, without grave goods. Burial in wooden coffins was rare although this method of burial has been recorded in other similarly early graveyards in Wales (Edwards and Lane, 1992, 6). Shroud burials are also noted from other Welsh Early Christian cemeteries. However, the lack of special graves within, for example, timber structures and ditched enclosures, is very apparent at Llandough.

7.10 Refining the chronology of the development of the cemeteries at Llandough will necessarily be speculative until more radiocarbon dates are obtained. Most of the pottery is residual and artefacts such as the Roman beads could well be heirlooms. The expanded cemetery at Llandough was established by the latter part of the 10th century to judge from the radiocarbon date from Burial 228 and burial could well have continued in Area IV until the demise of the monastery, shortly after the Norman conquest. The marked absence of sherds of medieval pottery from the graves, in contrast to those associated with the timber building, strongly suggest that regular burial in graves had ceased by the 12-14th centuries.

7.11 The latest burial activity at Llandough is the cluster of infant burials in Areas III and IV. No direct dating was recovered, although the concentration of infants suggests a special cause or event. Prof. Charles Thomas has kindly drawn our attention, by way of comparison, with the burial of children within the churchyard of Tintagel, Cornwall, which might be associated with a historically recorded plague in the winter of 1546-7 (Nowakowski and Thomas 1992, 27-9). A programme of radiocarbon dates which would include these infant burials would certainly shed light on the final use of the cemetery and any relationship with the timber building to the east.

7.12 It cannot be over stressed that the results presented in this report are the result of only preliminary analysis. In particular the skeletal remains possess huge potential for scientific study, especially so in the light of the postulated late-Roman/post-Roman continuity of the site. Full analysis of this material will necessarily take time, but the results will surely be of cardinal importance for our understanding of the inhabitants of the monastery of St Docco and their neighbours.

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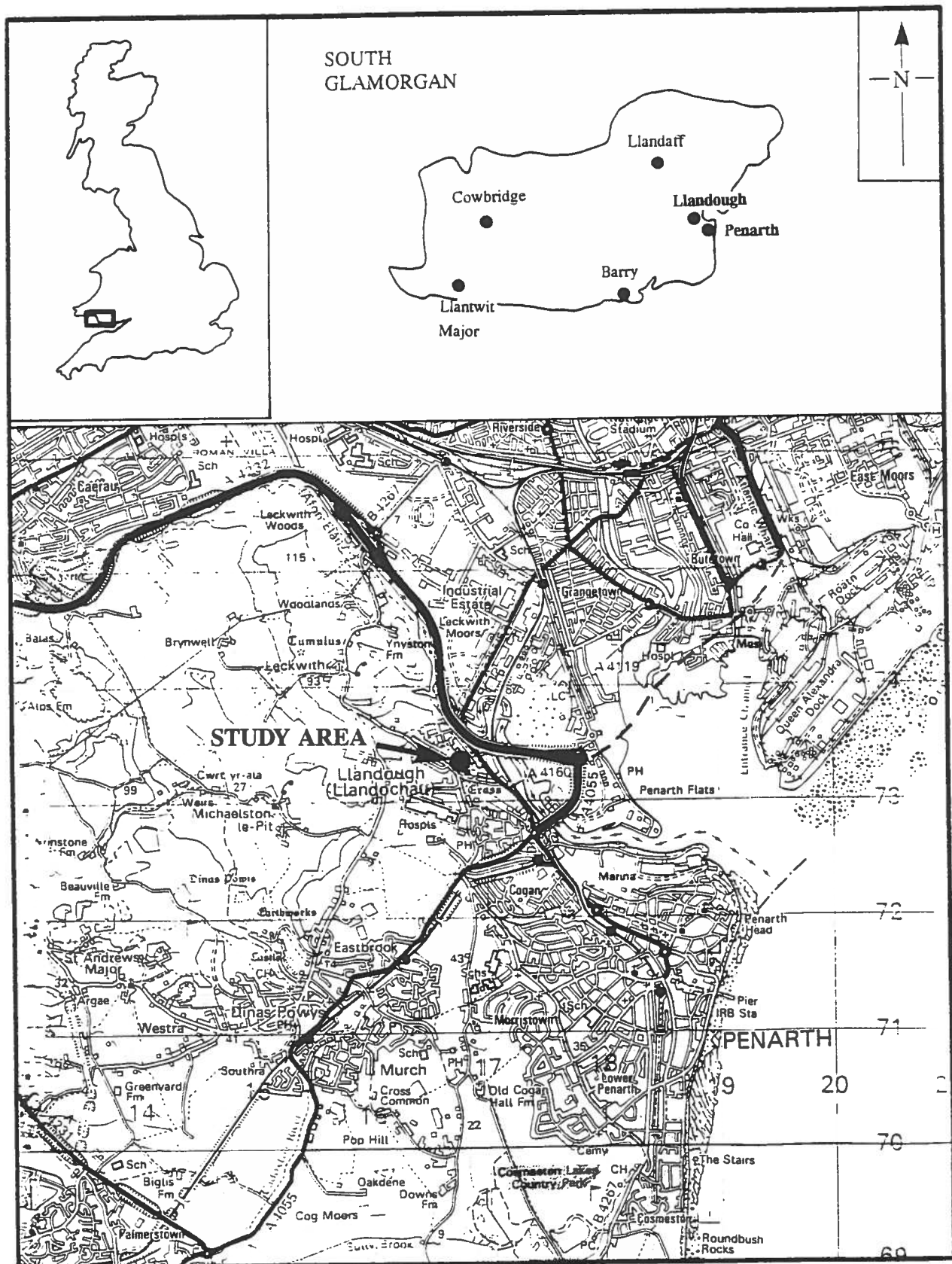
The success of the excavation depended on its core team of excavators who worked in the most difficult of conditions, namely Mark Brett, Jon Matthews, Cate Davies, Stephen Forbes, Ian Dennis, Jim Turner, Lisa Powell, Rebecca Vaughan, Kim Watkins, Steve O'Rourke and Barbara Inglis. Several members of CAT staff and students and graduates of the University of Wales, Cardiff, also worked and volunteered on-site and thanks are in particular due to Huw Sherlock, Kate Bonner, Brian Jones, Phil Hodges, Brona Langton, Paul Charlton, Andy Manning, Jane Stewart, Jane Hughes, Liz Pimblett, Gillian Thomas, Susan Fielding, Kimberley Dore, Louise Barber, Christine Bloor, Duncan Robertson, Richard Ashton, Emma Roden and Catrin Edwards.

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Figure 1. LOCATION OF LLANDOUGH



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Figure 2. 1979 AND 1994 EXCAVATION AREAS

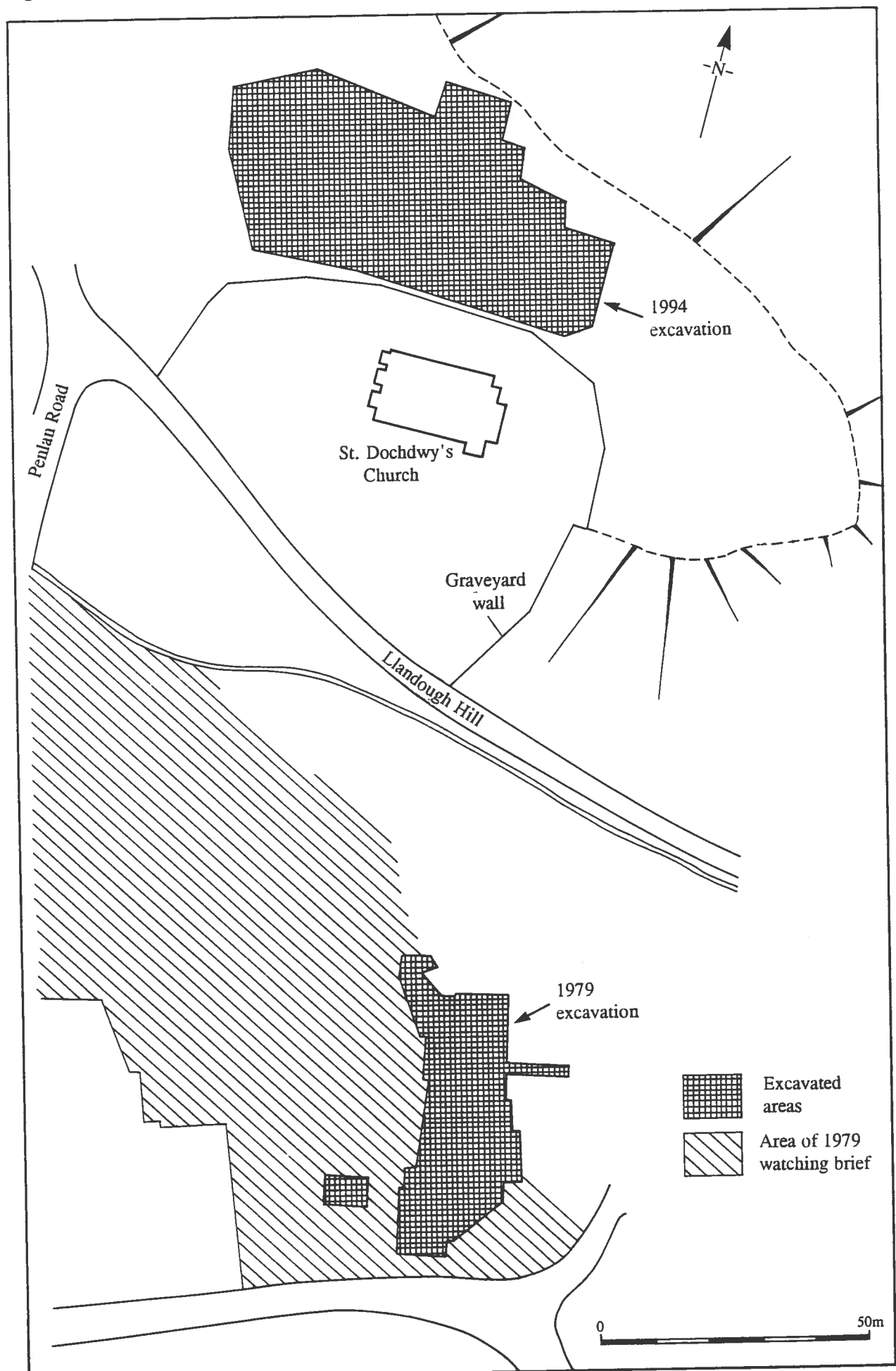


Figure 3. SITE PLAN

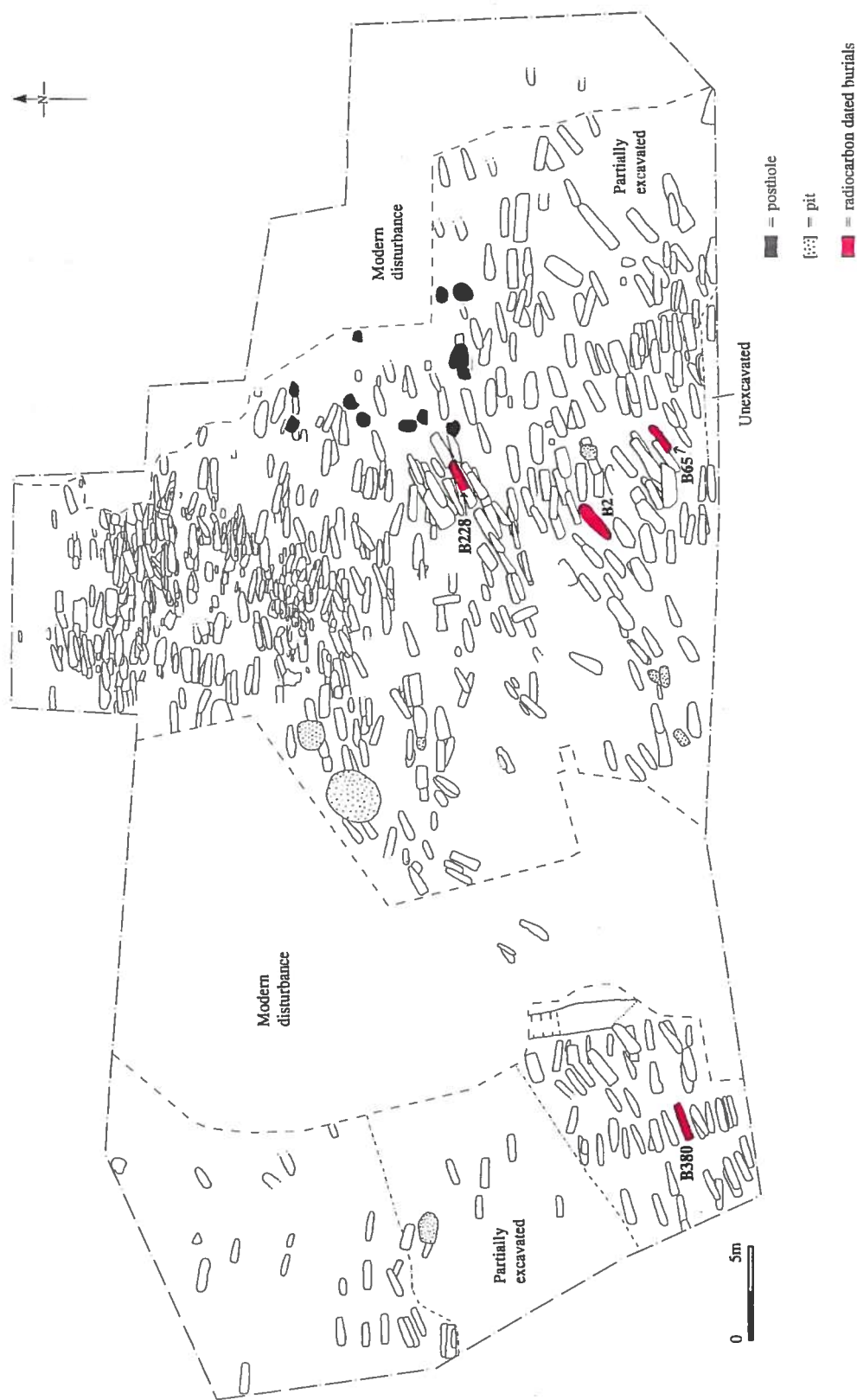


Figure 4. OVERALL PLAN OF THE CEMETERY DEFINING AREAS I-IV

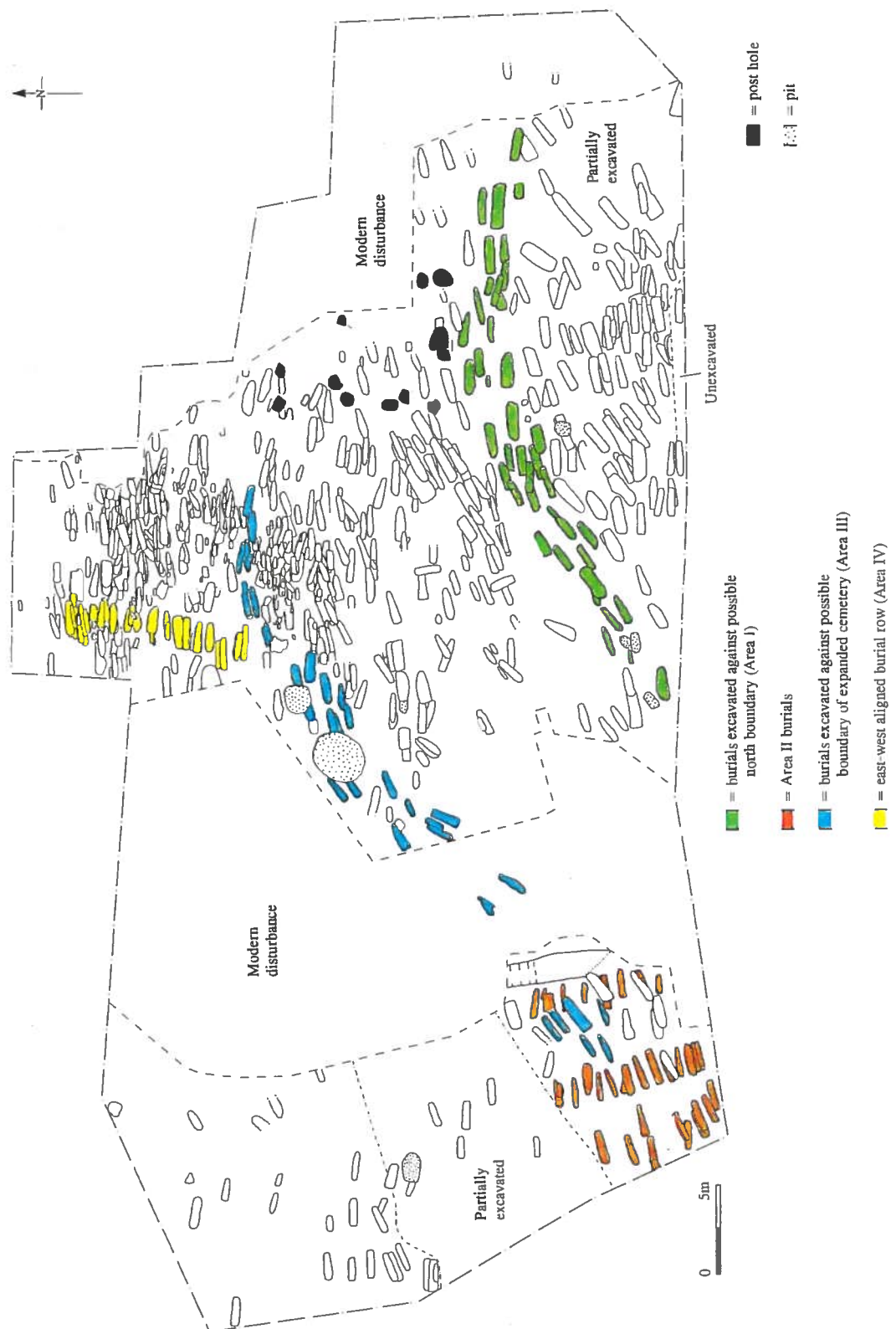


Figure 5. DISTRIBUTION OF STONE-LINED GRAVES, WOODEN COFFINS AND PILLOW-STONE BURIALS

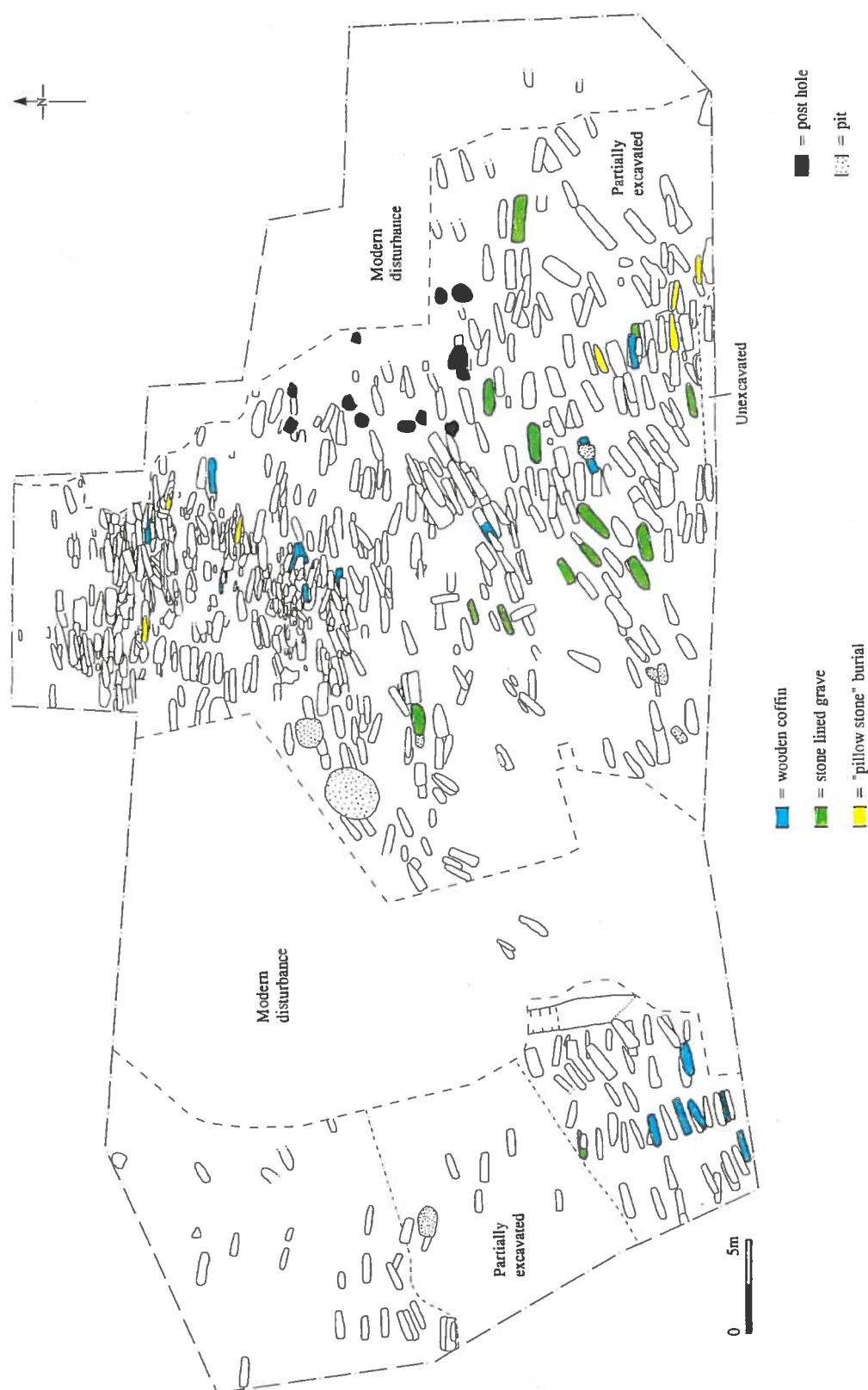


Figure 6. DISTRIBUTION OF FINDS

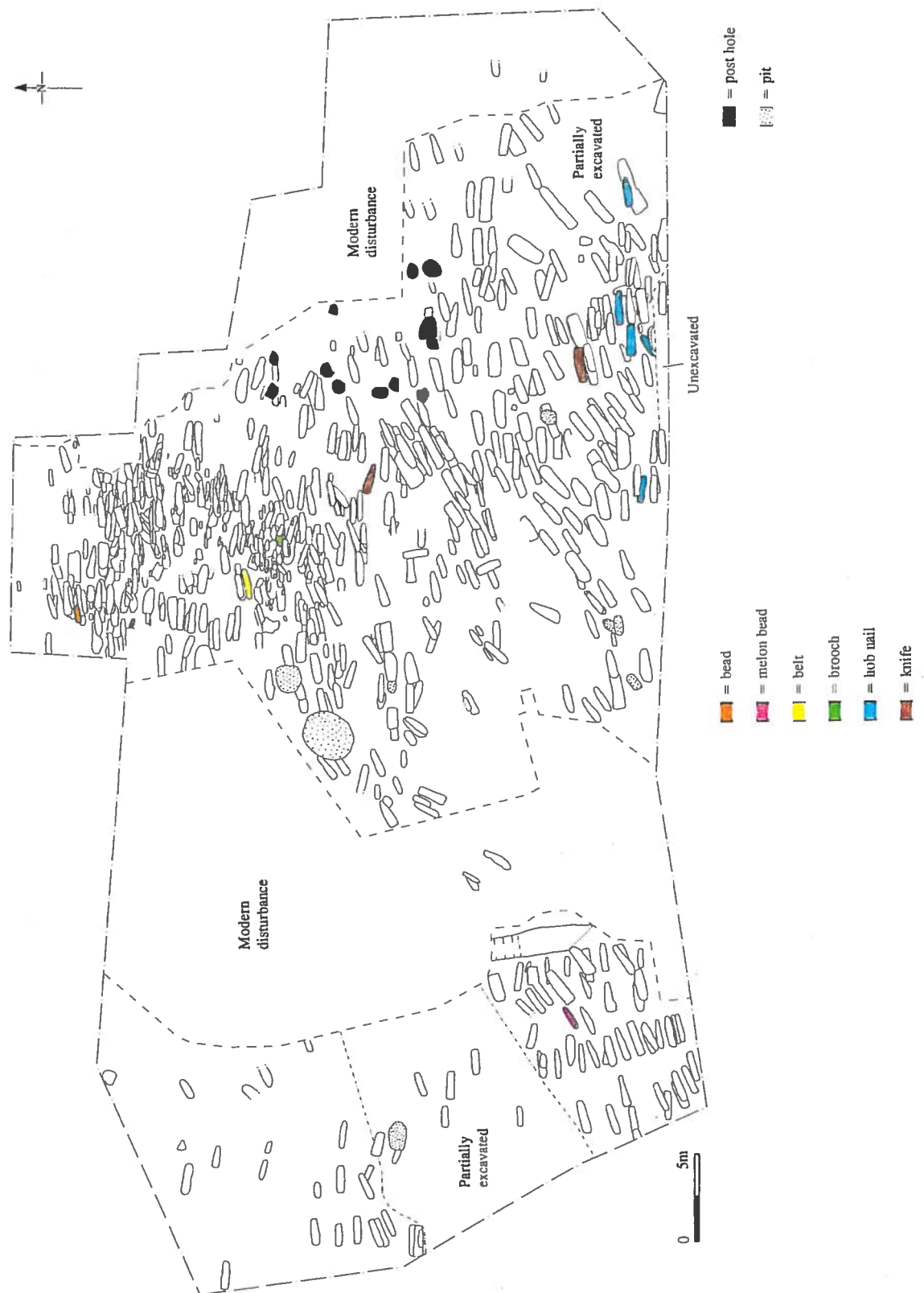


Figure 7. DISTRIBUTION OF LATE IRON AGE, ROMAN AND BII POTTERY

